

Weekly Theta Shortlist — 2026-09-14

Window: Run date 2026-09-14. 50-day earnings-free window closes 2026-11-03. Names reporting on or before that date are excluded.

Regime This Week

VIX closed 14.4 Friday — second-lowest print since Dec 2025 — with realized and implied both compressed and \$6.2T Sept 18 opex looming, so dealer-gamma unwind is the near-term supply-demand risk, not vol expansion per se. **Hot August core CPI (+0.3% MoM) has flipped Fed pricing hawkish:** Polymarket has 79% odds of a 25bp HIKE at Sept 15-16 FOMC — an unusual print for a theta seller, since the trade lifetime spans the meeting even if it opens Monday. WTI at \$99 (down 4.6% Friday but elevated on the year) keeps energy IV bid, though energy names are largely inside the earnings window and excluded here. Semi IV collapsed 40% in 30 sessions per Citadel — those names were already off the list; the collapse just confirms it.

Tier A — November reporters (cleanest window)

#	Ticker	Sector	Mkt Cap	Est. IV band	Est. HV band	Weeklies	Next Earnings	DTE	Justification
1	HD	Cons Disc	~\$355B	~22-26%	~20-24%	Yes	Nov 17, 2026	64	Mature big-cap retailer; steady IV regime; penny-wide options. Date via HD IR/Zacks. Verify at IBKR.
2	WMT	Cons Staples	~\$780B	~18-22%	~16-20%	Yes	Nov 19, 2026	66	Defensive, low HV; IV likely at/below 20% floor — check at IBKR. Confirmed via Walmart IR page. Verify at IBKR.
3	TGT	Cons Disc	~\$65B	~30-38%	~28-35%	Yes	Nov 18, 2026	65	Higher IV than peer retail (guidance volatility). Fits band cleanly. Confirmed via Target IR. Verify at IBKR.
4	LOW	Cons Disc	~\$150B	~26-30%	~24-28%	Yes	Nov 18, 2026 (est)	~65	Q3 date not yet formally announced on Lowe's IR page; mid-Nov pattern strong from prior year. Date unconfirmed — recheck. Verify at IBKR.
5	CSCO	Info Tech	~\$260B	~22-26%	~20-24%	Yes	~Nov 11, 2026 (est)	~58	Fiscal Q1 pattern — CSCO reported Nov 12 last year. Mature networking name, contained beta. Date unconfirmed by primary IR. Verify at IBKR.
6	TJX	Cons Disc	~\$145B	~22-26%	~20-24%	Yes	~Nov 18, 2026 (est)	~65	Off-price retail; Q3 pattern Nov 19 last year. Date unconfirmed by IR. Verify at IBKR.
7	MDT	Healthcare	~\$115B	~20-24%	~18-22%	Yes	~Nov 18, 2026 (est)	~65	Medical devices; fiscal Q2 pattern (reported Nov 18, 2025). Date unconfirmed. Verify at IBKR.
8	DE	Industrials	~\$135B	~26-32%	~24-30%	Yes	~Nov 25, 2026 (est)	~72	Fiscal Q4 pattern (Nov 26, 2025 last year). Ag cycle-sensitive but not in crisis. Date unconfirmed by IR. Verify at IBKR.
9	INTU	Info Tech	~\$170B	~28-34%	~26-32%	Yes	~Nov 20, 2026 (est)	~67	Fiscal Q1 pattern (Nov 20 last cycle confirmed by Intuit IR press release). Higher IV than staples. Verify at IBKR.

Tier B — December reporters

#	Ticker	Sector	Mkt Cap	Est. IV band	Est. HV band	Weeklies	Next Earnings	DTE	Justification
10	COST	Cons Staples	~\$410B	~18-22%	~16-20%	Yes	~Dec 10, 2026 (est)	~87	Fiscal Q1 pattern (Dec 11, 2025 last year). IV likely at/below 20% floor — check at IBKR. Very clean name. Verify at IBKR.

#	Ticker	Sector	Mkt Cap	Est. IV band	Est. HV band	Weeklies	Next Earnings	DTE	Justification
11	AZO	Cons Disc	~\$60B	~22-26%	~20-24%	Yes	~Dec 8, 2026 (est)	~85	Fiscal Q1 auto-parts retail; low-drama; longer window past the 50-day cutoff. Date unconfirmed by IR. Verify at IBKR.

Changes vs Last Week

First run — no comparison.

Excluded This Week (With Reason)

- **JPM, BAC, C, WFC, GS, MS**: Q3 earnings mid-October — inside 50-day window.
- **MSFT, GOOGL, META, AAPL, AMZN**: Q3 earnings late-October — inside window; several also below 20% IV floor.
- **XOM, CVX, PSX, OXY**: late-October reports; energy IV bid but excluded on earnings screen.
- **MCD, KO, PEP, SBUX**: consumer defensives reporting late-Oct.
- **V, MA, BRK.B**: late-Oct / early-Nov reports.
- **UNH, LLY, PFE, JNJ, CVS, ABBV**: healthcare Q3 mid-late Oct.
- **NVDA, AMD, AVGO, MU, INTC, TSM**: policy exclusion (semis); IV band too high anyway.
- **TSLA, PLTR, MSTR, SMCI, ARM, COIN**: excluded per rule (high-beta / meme / crypto-adjacent).
- **BKNG, ADBE, CRM, NKE**: earnings inside window (NKE fiscal Q1 late-Sept).

Sizing Note for This Week

Compressed VIX combined with a hiking-bias FOMC on Tuesday-Wednesday puts theta sellers on the wrong side of both the tail-risk and the IV entry point. **Cap deployed capital at ~60-70% of a normal week** — the FOMC print falls in the first few days of the trade lifetime, when gamma is thin and both a 25bp hike and a hold surprise cut asymmetrically against the seller. Bias credit spreads (defined risk) over naked short options this week, and lean on Tier A names with tighter IV bands (WMT, MDT, COST) rather than the higher-IV reach names (TGT, INTU, DE). Skip strangles on any name where the IV/HV ratio would need to be verified as > 130% just to justify premium — under-compensated for the FOMC event risk. One position per sector; keep Cons Disc concentration in check given HD/LOW/TGT/TJX overlap.

Verify at IBKR Before Trading

Every row above needs live confirmation of: 13w and 26w IV percentile > 50; IV in 20-40% band; HV in 20-40% band; IV/HV between 100% and 150%; and no unreported earnings amendment. This list is a filtered starting universe, not a completed screen.

Sources

1. Citadel Securities, September Setup — VIX 14.4; \$6.2T Sept 18 opex; semi IV collapse. citadelsecurities.com/news-and-insights/global-market-intelligence/september-setup/
2. Polymarket — Sept 2026 FOMC odds (79% 25bp hike). polymarket.com/event/fed-decision-in-september-762
3. Forbes Advisor — WTI \$99.22, Sept 11 2026. forbes.com/advisor/investing/oil-prices-today/
4. CNBC — Aug 2026 CPI beat, Fed hike setup. cnbc.com/2026/09/11/cpi-inflation-report-august-2026.html
5. Walmart IR — Q3 FY2027 earnings Nov 19, 2026 (primary). corporate.walmart.com/news/events/fy2027-q3-earnings-release
6. Target IR — Q3 2026 earnings Nov 18, 2026 (primary). corporate.target.com/investors/events-presentations
7. Home Depot IR (via Zacks calendar cross-check) — Q3 2026 earnings Nov 17, 2026. ir.homedepot.com/financial-reports/quarterly-earnings/2026
8. Intuit IR (last-cycle press release) — Q1 FY26 released Nov 20. investors.intuit.com/news-events/press-releases/detail/1278
9. TJX IR — Q3 FY26 Nov 19, 2025 baseline for pattern. investor.tjx.com/news-releases/news-release-details/tjx-companies-inc-reports-q3-fy26-results-comp-sales-growth-5
10. Nasdaq / Zacks earnings calendars — cross-check attempted for LOW, DE, MDT, CSCO, AZO, COST; returned "data not available" or historical only. Dates for these names are pattern estimates and lagged in-table.
11. IG Week Ahead 14 September 2026 — calendar reference. ig.com/ae/news-and-trade-ideas/week-ahead--14-september-2026-260911

Research shortlist only. Not trade advice. No IV percentiles, HV percentiles, or IV/HV ratios have been sourced live; every band is a directional estimate to be verified at execution in IBKR.